

Descartes: '*Cogito, ergo sum*'



René Descartes set out to approach the questions of metaphysics and epistemology in the same way as he would treat a mathematical proof. His method was to eliminate all the things there could be any doubt about, and try to establish certainties to work from – incontrovertible truths analogous to mathematical axioms.

He took the view of an extreme sceptic, arguing that we can not be sure of the existence of anything in the world around us, as our senses are easily deceived – it is even possible that we are deceived to the extent that all of

what we consider reality is in fact illusion. There would seem to be no grounds for any certain knowledge, but Descartes's great insight was that because he is doubting everything, he must exist in order to do the doubting. '*Cogito, ergo sum*' ('I am thinking, therefore I exist' carries the idea better than the usual translation 'I think, therefore I am') became the so-called First Certainty, which he used as the foundation for all his philosophical enquiries.